



FOLKLORE FINDER
FIELD GUIDE SERIES

FIELD GUIDE No.1

BIRTH of Albion

LEGENDS · SIGHTINGS · HISTORY · LOCATIONS



A companion to the Folklore Finder Atlas

Birth of Albion

Before the histories, Britain had a birth-story. Exiled Trojans led by Brutus, great-grandson of Aeneas, are said to have landed at Totnes to find an island held by giants — Gogmagog and his kind — whom they cast down to claim the land, renaming Albion as Britain. These are the legends of that founding: the Trojan founders, the last giants of Albion, and the mythic figures woven into the origin of the island itself.

The 'Matter of Britain' gave the island a legendary prehistory reaching back to the fall of Troy. Geoffrey of Monmouth's *Historia Regum Britanniae* (c.1136) fixed the story in its familiar form — Brutus and his followers settling an Albion inhabited only by giants, Corineus wrestling Gogmagog into the sea off the Cornish coast, and a line of legendary kings descending toward Lear, Lud and Cymbeline. Though wholly unhistorical, the tale was widely believed for centuries and left its mark on the landscape, from the Brutus Stone at Totnes to the Gog and Magog effigies still carried in the Lord Mayor's Show.

WHAT'S INSIDE



Introduction

Origins and meaning of the theme.



Distribution Map

Where the legends are reported.



Legend Profiles

Individual stories from across the isles.



In the Field

A companion for your own searches.



History & Folklore

How the legends evolved over time.



Reading the Signs

How to know one when you meet it.



Places to Visit

Real locations linked to the legends.



Explorer's Checklist

Track the legends you've discovered.



12 PAGES

PDF format



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Where the legends are found

Every marker is a legend in this guide, placed where its story is rooted. Absence of a marker does not mean absence of a legend.



● Reported legend · 8 sites across Britain & Ireland

How to know one when you meet it

The tradition is remarkably consistent across the islands. These are the marks that recur — the grammar of the black dog.

Eyes like coals

Burning eyes — red, yellow, or 'the size of saucers' — are the surest mark. To meet that gaze was, in most tellings, to be marked for a death within the year.

Unnatural size

Larger than any living dog; 'big as a calf' is the phrase used from Norfolk to the Highlands. Sheer size is what sets the spectral hound apart from a stray.

Silence & vanishing

It makes little sound and leaves no track. It falls into step beside you, then is simply gone — most often at a boundary: a gate, a bridge, a stile.

Thresholds & crossroads

Black dogs keep to in-between places — parish bounds, old roads, lychgates and crossroads — the very ground where the living and the dead were thought to meet.

Chains & fire

A dragging chain, a reek of sulphur, or a body wreathed in flame mark the more demonic hounds, especially in the tales of the south-west.

Omen or guardian?

Not every black dog brings death. Some, like the church grim, guard consecrated ground; others walk a lone traveller safely home. Read the errand, not just the beast.

Bran the Blessed

LONDON



The Story

Bran the Blessed — Bendigeidfran — is the giant-king of Britain at the heart of the Second Branch of the Mabinogi, a figure so vast that no house could ever contain him and so mighty that he waded the Irish Sea at the head of his host, his musicians playing on his back. When his sister Branwen, married to the King of Ireland, was abused and set to drudge in his kitchens, Bran led an army across the water to avenge her. The war was catastrophic, all but annihilating both sides, and Bran himself was wounded in the foot by a poisoned spear. Knowing he was dying, he commanded his seven surviving companions to cut off his head, which went on talking and feasting with them for many years in an enchanted timelessness, before they bore it at last to London and buried it on the White Hill — the site, tradition holds, of the Tower of London — facing France, so that as long as it lay there no invader could conquer Britain. King Arthur, the legend adds, later dug it up in his pride, trusting only his own strength to defend the land; and the ravens that are still kept at the Tower are said to be the lingering guardianship of Bran, whose name means 'raven'.

“A giant king of Britain so vast no house could contain him.”

AT A GLANCE

REGION
London

TYPE
Giant

ALSO KNOWN AS
—

MOTIFS
sea, guardian, arthurian

READ THE FULL LEGEND
folklorefinder.uk/legends/bran-the-blessed

Brutus of Troy

TOTNES, DEVON



The Story

Brutus of Troy is the legendary founder and first king of Britain, the figure with whom the medieval British traced their nation back to the heroes of antiquity. According to Geoffrey of Monmouth's 12th-century *History of the Kings of Britain*, Brutus was a great-grandson of Aeneas of Troy, exiled after accidentally killing his father, who gathered a band of the scattered Trojans and led them in search of a home. The goddess Diana, consulted at a ruined temple, prophesied that he would find an island in the western ocean, beyond the setting sun, that was destined to be his. That island was Albion, inhabited only by a race of giants. Local legend says Brutus and his followers made their landing at Totnes in Devon, and the very stone on which he first set foot is still pointed out, set into the pavement of Fore Street and known as the Brutus Stone. His champion Corineus, who took Cornwall for his portion and gave it his name, wrestled the greatest of the giants — Gogmagog — and hurled him from the cliffs to his death, clearing the land for the newcomers. Brutus renamed the island Britain after himself, and its people the Britons, and founded a capital on the Thames he called Troia Nova, 'New Troy', which in time became London. Though the whole story is a learned invention of the Middle Ages with no root in real history, it was believed for centuries and gave Britain a Trojan origin to rival Rome's — and at Totnes the Brutus Stone keeps the foundation legend literally underfoot.

"Great-grandson of Aeneas, exiled from Troy and guided by the goddess Diana to an island of giants, Brutus stepped..."

AT A GLANCE

REGION

Totnes, Devon

TYPE

Legendary Figure

ALSO KNOWN AS

—

MOTIFS

origin, founder

READ THE FULL LEGEND

folklorefinder.uk/legends/brutus-of-troy

LEGEND PROFILE

Corineus

CORNWALL



The Story

Corineus is the founding giant-slayer of Cornwall in the legendary history of Britain set down by Geoffrey of Monmouth. A Trojan warrior and companion of Brutus, the supposed first king of Britain, Corineus was famed above all for his delight in wrestling giants, and when the Trojans found the island of Albion held by a race of them, he relished the fight. For his prowess he was granted the western land that took his name, Corineia — Cornwall — the corner of Britain where the giants were thickest. His greatest bout was with their champion, Gogmagog, a monster of huge stature: the two grappled on the cliffs above the sea near Plymouth until Corineus, having had three ribs broken, heaved the giant up and hurled him from the heights to be dashed on the rocks below, at a place long called 'Gogmagog's Leap'. Through Corineus the medieval British were given a heroic, Trojan pedigree and an explanation for the giant-haunted reputation of their westernmost county.

"The Trojan hero granted Cornwall as his kingdom after helping Brutus defeat the giants of Albion."

AT A GLANCE

REGION
Cornwall

TYPE
Legendary Figure

ALSO KNOWN AS
—

MOTIFS
sea, coast

READ THE FULL LEGEND
folklorefinder.uk/legends/corineus

Gog and Magog

LONDON



The Story

Gog and Magog are the guardian giants of the City of London, the last survivors of a race of giants said to have inhabited Britain — or Albion — before the coming of man. In the legendary history popularised by Geoffrey of Monmouth, Brutus of Troy and his companion Corineus came to these shores and overcame the native giants; the greatest was hurled into the sea, and the survivors set to labour as porters at the gate of the founders' new city. For centuries their effigies have stood guard at London's Guildhall, and carved figures of the two giants are carried through the streets in the Lord Mayor's Show, a custom recorded since the fifteenth century. The wickerwork and wooden giants have been destroyed and remade many times — lost in the Great Fire, shattered in the Blitz — and always restored, for the city regards them as its protectors. Gog and Magog bind London to the oldest layer of British legend: the myth of the giants of Albion who walked the land before history began.

"The last of the giants of Albion, their effigies carried in the Lord Mayor's Show since at least the reign of Henry V."

AT A GLANCE

REGION
London

TYPE
Giant

ALSO KNOWN AS
—

MOTIFS
guardian

READ THE FULL LEGEND
folklorefinder.uk/legends/gog-and-magog

Walk the ground the stories haunt



Brutus of Troy

TOTNES, DEVON

Great-grandson of Aeneas, exiled from Troy and guided by the goddess Diana to an island of giants, Brutus stepped ashore at Totnes to found Britain — giving the land, and its people, his name.

folklorefinder.uk/legends/brutus-of-troy



Jack the Giant Killer

LAND'S END, CORNWALL

A Cornish farmer's lad who dug a pit to topple the giant Cormoran and won a belt naming him Jack the Giant Killer — then went on slaying giants the length of King Arthur's Britain.

folklorefinder.uk/legends/jack-the-giant-killer



Bran the Blessed

LONDON

A giant king of Britain so vast no house could contain him. He carried his armies across the Irish Sea on his own back. His severed head, buried beneath the Tower of London, was said to protect Britain from invasion — until Arthur dug it up.

folklorefinder.uk/legends/bran-the-blessed



Corineus

CORNWALL

The Trojan hero granted Cornwall as his kingdom after helping Brutus defeat the giants of Albion. He delighted in wrestling giants — his greatest feat was hurling Gogmagog from a Cornish cliff into the sea below. The cliff has been known ever since as Gogmagog's Leap.

folklorefinder.uk/legends/corineus

EXPLORER TIP

Many sites are wild, remote or private. Stay safe, respect the land and follow local guidance.

Dusk and the dead of night, and most of all the turning points of the year — the old fire-festivals, and the nights around a funeral or a storm.

Lonely lanes and green roads, lychgates and churchyards, parish boundaries, bridges and the coast path.
Black dogs keep to edges.

The eyes, the size, the sound (or silence), and where it appears and vanishes. Mark the exact spot — the tradition is rooted in real places.

Never trespass; ask permission on private land. Don't go alone after dark, tell someone your route, and leave every site as you found it.

Date · Place · What you saw

How the legends took shape

The 'Matter of Britain' gave the island a legendary prehistory reaching back to the fall of Troy. Geoffrey of Monmouth's *Historia Regum Britanniae* (c.1136) fixed the story in its familiar form — Brutus and his followers settling an Albion inhabited only by giants, Corineus wrestling Gogmagog into the sea off the Cornish coast, and a line of legendary kings descending toward Lear, Lud and Cymbeline. Though wholly unhistorical, the tale was widely believed for centuries and left its mark on the landscape, from the Brutus Stone at Totnes to the Gog and Magog effigies still carried in the Lord Mayor's Show.

SIMILAR CREATURES

Black dogs shade into a wider family of spectral hounds and guardian beasts — the barghest of the north, the Manx moddey dhoo, the Welsh gwyllgi, the church grim set to guard consecrated ground, and the Cù Sith of the Highlands. Most share the same core: a great black dog, burning eyes, and an errand between this world and the next.

EXPLORER'S CHECKLIST

Track your discoveries

Tick off each legend as you track it down.

- ☐ **Bran the Blessed** *London*
- ☐ **Brutus of Troy** *Totnes*
- ☐ **Corineus** *Cornwall*
- ☐ **Gog and Magog** *London*

- ☐ **Gogmagog** *Cornwall*
- ☐ **Hafren** *Welsh Marches*
- ☐ **Jack the Giant Killer** *Land's End*
- ☐ **Warrior of the Gog Magog Hills** *Cambridgeshir*



ABOUT THE SERIES

The Folklore Finder Field Guide Series explores the creatures, places and people of British and Irish folklore — one theme at a time. Each guide is a companion to the interactive atlas at folklorefinder.uk.

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